A FOUNDER'S READING OF MOMENTUM

The Business Momentum Score

Five minutes of honest answering
to see whether your business is accelerating, steady, slowing, or stalling.

Built on 9 years of coaching 95 businesses
and the operator research of Collins, Sutherland, Horowitz,
Wickman, and the Customer Success Management literature.

by

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FOREWORD

Direction matters more than position. Always.

Two businesses sit in the same room. The first does two crores in annual revenue and is sliding backwards. The second does one crore and is climbing steadily. Most observers would call the first the healthier business. They would be wrong.

Position tells you where a business is today. Direction tells you where it will be in twelve months. A business with a score of six out of ten that is accelerating is in a structurally better place than a business with a score of eight that is slowing. The first compounds. The second decays.

Most founders spend their time measuring position. Revenue this month. Headcount this quarter. Margin this year. Snapshots. Useful, but blind to trajectory. This audit measures something different. Direction of change across four dimensions of your business over the last six months. Nine questions. Five minutes of honest answering. A momentum signal at the end that tells you, with reasonable confidence, whether your business is gathering speed or losing it.

The audit will not tell you what to fix. It will tell you whether you have the kind of problem that needs fixing in the first place, or the kind that needs preserving and compounding. Five minutes is a small price to pay for that distinction.

Most founders measure where they are.
Few stop to measure which way they are moving.

HOW MOMENTUM ACTUALLY WORKS

Four dimensions. One direction at a time.

Business momentum is not a single number. It is the resultant of four distinct dimensions that operate on different timescales and respond to different interventions. A business can be accelerating in one and stalling in another. The mistake most founders make is treating momentum as a feeling. It is not. It is measurable, dimension by dimension, against the last six months of operating reality.

01 Revenue Momentum

The direction of change in revenue, pipeline health, and customer quality over the last six months. The dimension that compounds fastest, in both directions.

02 Operational Momentum

The direction of change in how smoothly the business runs and how much capability your team has added. The dimension that quietly determines whether revenue gains stick or evaporate.

03 Problem Resolution Momentum

The direction of change in whether your business actually solves problems permanently or keeps fighting the same ones in new forms. The dimension that distinguishes businesses that mature from businesses that simply age.

04 Founder Momentum

The direction of change in the founder's own bandwidth, clarity, and energy. The dimension that determines whether everything above can continue compounding or will eventually crash into a human ceiling.

The audit that follows tests all four dimensions in nine questions. Answer each one against the last six months only. Not against your best month ever. Not against your plans for next quarter. Against the actual trajectory you have lived through.

Source: Collins, Good to Great (Random House) · Sutherland, Scrum (Crown) · Customer Success Management research, Springer 2024

HOW TO USE THIS AUDIT

Four simple rules.

01 **ANSWER AGAINST THE LAST SIX MONTHS**

Every question asks about direction of change compared to six months ago. Not five years. Not your founding story. The last six months of operating reality.

02 **RATE FROM ONE TO FIVE**

One means getting significantly worse. Three means roughly the same. Five means significantly better. Default to a lower number when uncertain. A low rating surfaces a real direction. An inflated rating hides one.

03 **TOTAL YOUR SCORE**

Add all nine ratings. The total falls between nine and forty-five. The band you land in reveals your momentum signal, which is the actionable diagnosis of the audit.

04 **DO NOT REDESIGN MID-AUDIT**

Resist the urge to start fixing problems as you find them. The audit is a diagnostic, not an intervention. Finish all nine questions first. Then read the signal. Then decide.

DIMENSION 01

Revenue Momentum

ABOUT THIS DIMENSION

The direction your top line is moving, the health of what feeds it, and whether the customers being added are better than the ones being replaced. Revenue momentum compounds faster than any other dimension. It also decays faster. A six-month slowdown rarely corrects itself without deliberate structural intervention.

RATE EACH FROM ONE TO FIVE

01.	Compared to six months ago, monthly revenue is moving in the right direction.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5
02.	The pipeline of new opportunities is healthier than it was six months ago.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5
03.	The quality of clients you are attracting is improving. They pay more, complain less, and stay longer than the clients of six months ago.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5

13 to 15: Revenue momentum is accelerating.
9 to 12: Revenue momentum is steady.
6 to 8: Revenue momentum is slowing.
3 to 5: Revenue momentum has stalled.

YOUR SCORE _____

BOOK INSIGHT

The Flywheel

Jim Collins observed across the great companies he studied a recurring structural pattern. The businesses that compounded did not arrive at compounding through a single heroic decision. They arrived through a flywheel. A small set of disciplined moves repeated consistently until the system itself began to spin under its own weight. The revenue businesses that accelerate are not the ones with the most ambitious targets. They are the ones whose flywheel has been turning longest in the same direction.

Jim Collins, Good to Great (Random House)

DIMENSION 02

Operational Momentum

ABOUT THIS DIMENSION

The direction in which your operating reality is moving. Whether the same business is now easier to run than it was six months ago, or harder. Whether your team has absorbed responsibility or pushed it back upward. Operational momentum is invisible until it isn't, at which point it determines whether revenue gains stick or quietly reverse.

RATE EACH FROM ONE TO FIVE

04.	The business runs more smoothly today than it did six months ago. Fewer fires. Fewer surprises.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5
05.	Your team is more capable now than they were six months ago. You are delegating more, not less.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5

9 to 10: Operational momentum is accelerating.
6 to 8: Operational momentum is steady.
4 to 5: Operational momentum is slowing.
2 to 3: Operational momentum has stalled.

YOUR SCORE _____

BOOK INSIGHT

Scrum and the Doubling Effect

Jeff Sutherland's research into operational performance surfaced a structural claim most operators resist. The right operating cadence can double productivity in any team within ninety days. Not through harder work but through tighter feedback loops, shorter cycles, and the disciplined elimination of waste. Operational momentum is not a function of effort. It is a function of cadence. Most struggling businesses have cadence problems disguised as effort problems.

Jeff Sutherland, Scrum: The Art of Doing Twice the Work in Half the Time (Crown)

DIMENSION 03

Problem Resolution Momentum

ABOUT THIS DIMENSION

The direction in which your business is solving the problems it encounters. Whether the issues that bothered you six months ago have been resolved permanently, or whether they keep returning in new forms. This dimension separates businesses that mature over time from businesses that simply accumulate age. Both look similar from the outside. Only one is actually growing up.

RATE EACH FROM ONE TO FIVE

06.	The problems that bothered you six months ago are no longer bothering you today.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5
07.	When a new problem appears, you solve it once and it stays solved. Not the same issue coming back wearing a different face.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5

9 to 10: Problem resolution momentum is accelerating.
6 to 8: Problem resolution momentum is steady.
4 to 5: Problem resolution momentum is slowing.
2 to 3: Problem resolution momentum has stalled.

YOUR SCORE _____

BOOK INSIGHT

There's Got to Be a Better Way

Repenning and Kieffer's MIT research on structured problem-diagnosis identified the single most common operator failure. Solving the same problem repeatedly while believing each instance is new. Their structured approach forces operators to ask a different question. What problem behind the problem keeps producing this problem? Businesses that mature ask this question. Businesses that simply age treat each symptom as the cause and remain surprised when it returns.

Nelson Repenning & Don Kieffer, There's Got to Be a Better Way (MIT)

DIMENSION 04

Founder Momentum

ABOUT THIS DIMENSION

The direction in which the founder's own bandwidth, clarity, and energy are moving. Most operator literature treats this as a wellness question. It is not. It is the structural ceiling that determines whether the other three dimensions can continue compounding or will eventually crash into a human limit. A founder losing momentum will cap the business they built, no matter how strong the other dimensions look.

RATE EACH FROM ONE TO FIVE

08.	You work fewer hours today than you did six months ago. And the business is doing better, not worse.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5
09.	You feel more clarity, more energy, and more in control of where the business is heading than you did six months ago.	[ ] 1 [ ] 2 [ ] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5

9 to 10: Founder momentum is accelerating.
6 to 8: Founder momentum is steady.
4 to 5: Founder momentum is slowing.
2 to 3: Founder momentum has stalled.

YOUR SCORE _____

BOOK INSIGHT

The Hard Thing About Hard Things

Ben Horowitz makes a structural argument that has aged remarkably well. The single highest-leverage investment any founder can make is in their own clarity. Every decision the business takes flows through the founder's mind. Cloudy thinking at the top compounds into cloudy execution everywhere. The founders who scale are not necessarily the smartest or the most experienced. They are the ones whose internal momentum has not stalled while everything outside them is moving faster.

Ben Horowitz, The Hard Thing About Hard Things (Harper Business)

READING YOUR SIGNAL

Add up all nine ratings. Find your signal.

Total your nine ratings. The number falls between nine and forty-five. Find the band below. The signal tells you which of four directional states your business is in, and what the right next move looks like. Total score matters less than which dimensions pulled you up or down. Glance back at your individual dimension scores after you read the overall signal. The pattern across dimensions tells you where to act first.

Score 36 to 45 — Accelerating

Your business is moving in the right direction across every dimension. Revenue is climbing, operations are tightening, problems stay solved, and you have more bandwidth than you did six months ago. You are not in a fix-it phase. You are in a scale-it phase. The risk here is the opposite of stagnation. It is dispersion. With momentum comes the temptation to chase too many new directions at once. Pick one growth lever and pour fuel on it. Decline three others, even if they look attractive.

Score 27 to 35 — Steady

Your business is stable. Probably profitable. Nothing is breaking, but nothing is dramatically improving either. You are running, not climbing. Steady is the most misread signal of the four. It feels like safety. Structurally, it is the precursor to slowing, because markets move whether you do or not. Steady is the right moment to install one new structural lever that creates forward direction. Not three. One.

Score 18 to 26 — Slowing

Something is dragging. Rarely a single big problem. Almost always a combination of smaller ones that have begun compounding against you. Revenue is flat or sliding. Operations feel heavier than they should. The same issues keep returning. You are still in motion but losing speed. Slowing is the most actionable signal of the four. The structural fix is to identify the single biggest bottleneck across the four dimensions and resolve it permanently with a working system, not another effort spike.

Score 9 to 17 — Stalling

Your business is no longer moving forward in any meaningful way. You are working harder than ever and getting less back. Problems multiply faster than you solve them. This is not a fix-one-thing situation. This is a step-back, see-clearly, rebuild-the-foundation situation. Do not pick a single lever to push. Pick a structured diagnostic instead. Clarity before construction. The wrong fix applied to a stalling business usually accelerates the stall.

WHAT EACH SIGNAL MEANS STRUCTURALLY

Position is a snapshot. Momentum is a story.

Two businesses with identical revenue can be in entirely different structural situations. The first is climbing. The second is sliding. Looked at on a single day, they appear interchangeable. Looked at over six months, they are nothing alike. The climbing business has compounding tailwind. The sliding one has compounding drag. Both forces, given enough time, become impossible to reverse without structural intervention.

This is why the audit measures direction rather than state. State is a photograph. Direction is a film. Photographs lie about businesses, often without meaning to. Films do not. Your signal score is a film of the last six months, played back as a single number. Whatever your business looks like on paper today, the signal tells you where paper is heading.

A founder who knows their signal can plan against it. A founder who only knows their position is gambling against momentum they have not yet measured. The Accelerating business consolidates and scales. The Steady business installs new direction. The Slowing business removes one bottleneck. The Stalling business steps back and rebuilds. Different signals, different moves. The wrong move for your signal is more dangerous than no move at all.

YOUR 90-DAY MOVE

What to do this week, before you even consider SPRINT.

Whichever signal you scored, there is real work you can do this week that does not require any external help. The point of this page is to make sure the audit produces action even if you never speak to me. That is what an honest lead magnet does.

If you scored Accelerating

Spend two hours this week listing every growth lever currently available to you. Pick one. Decline two others, even if they look attractive. Write down what specifically will tell you, in ninety days, whether the chosen lever has worked. Most founders in accelerating phases stall because they chase three new directions instead of compounding the one that is already working.

If you scored Steady

Look at your individual dimension scores. The lowest dimension is where steady will tip to slowing first. This week, identify the single structural change in that dimension that would shift it most. Not three changes. One. Then design a specific ninety-day commitment around that single change. Steady is the easiest signal to protect, and the hardest to notice slipping.

If you scored Slowing

List every problem in the business right now that has been on your mind for more than thirty days. Group them. Most of what looks like ten problems is two or three underlying ones surfacing in different places. Identify the single largest bottleneck underneath the group. That bottleneck is where your slowing is coming from. It needs a working system around it, not another effort spike from you personally.

If you scored Stalling

Do not pick a single fix this week. Picking the wrong fix on a stalling business accelerates the stall. Instead, take three hours to write down honestly what your business actually does, who actually pays for it, and what specifically has changed in the last six months. Most stalling businesses cannot answer those three questions clearly. The act of writing them is the first move out.

THE NEXT STEP

What this audit cannot do for you.

This audit was designed to do one thing well. Tell you whether your business is accelerating, steady, slowing, or stalling. If you have answered honestly, you now know which of those four states your business is in, which dimensions pulled your score up or down, and what to do this week. That is a real achievement. Most founders never get this clarity in a lifetime of running a business.

What this audit cannot do is identify the single biggest bottleneck underneath your slowing or stalling signal. It cannot design the working system that will resolve that bottleneck permanently. It cannot sit with you week after week as you build that system into your operating reality. The audit tells you direction. It does not build the engine that changes direction.

That is what SPRINT is for.

SPRINT

Strategic Problem Resolution & Implementation for Next-Level Transformation

An eight-session, one-on-one engagement that identifies the single biggest bottleneck behind your slowing or stalling signal and builds a working system around it. Not a coaching conversation. A construction project. You walk out with an operating system, not just a diagnosis.

Eight sessions, one per week, one hundred percent online. Each session designs and ships a specific component of the system. The eighth session is a handover. The system runs in your business with or without you in the room. That is the test.

For founders who scored Slowing or Steady. If your signal was Stalling, start with RAAG instead. Clarity before construction.

Apply at sureshbalachandar.in/sprint

FURTHER READING

The bookshelf this audit was built on.

If any of the Book Insights in this audit caught you, the original texts deserve your time. These are the books I returned to most often while designing the SPRINT engagement.

Good to Great by Jim Collins

The flywheel concept that anchors the Revenue Momentum dimension. Collins' framing of compounding direction over heroic moves is the single most useful idea in operator literature for SME founders.

Scrum: The Art of Doing Twice the Work in Half the Time by Jeff Sutherland

The cadence argument that anchors the Operational Momentum dimension. Sutherland shows operationally how the right rhythm doubles productivity without doubling effort.

There's Got to Be a Better Way by Nelson Repenning & Don Kieffer

MIT's structured problem-diagnosis approach. Anchors the Problem Resolution Momentum dimension. The clearest treatment of why the same problems keep returning.

The Hard Thing About Hard Things by Ben Horowitz

The founder-clarity argument that anchors the Founder Momentum dimension. Honest, unsentimental, and free of motivational language.

Traction by Gino Wickman

The EOS operating system. The clearest articulation of how businesses convert momentum into structure that compounds without founder attention.

Customer Success Management by Kleinaltenkamp, Prohl-Schwenke & Elgeti

The expansion engine argument. How the cheapest momentum in any business comes from the customers it already has.

Reinvent Your Business Model by Mark W. Johnson

The structural counterpart to this audit. Where the Growth Bottleneck Finder ends (architecture), SPRINT begins (system construction). Required reading for any founder whose signal is Slowing or Stalling.